

"wouldn't be caught dead" inside an opera house, concert hall or art gallery. I'm acquainted with many top-level businessmen and executives with Ivy League backgrounds who don't know the difference between a Corot and a chromo—and couldn't care less.

The "ant culture" bias appears to thrive at most levels of American society. It is reflected in a thousand and one facets of American life. The nauseating, moronic fare dished out to radio, television and motion picture audiences—and presumably relished by them—is one random example. The comparatively sparse attendance at museums and permanent art exhibitions is another. Only a tiny percentage of the population reads great books or listens to great music. It's doubtful if one in ten Americans is able to differentiate between a Doric and an Ionic column. Save for amateur theatrical groups or touring road companies, the legitimate theater is rare outside New York City.

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Americans like to boast that the United States is the richest nation on earth. They hardly seem to notice that in proportion to its material wealth and prosperity, the American people themselves are culturally poor, if not poverty-stricken.

The far-reaching and powerful influence of traditional American culture-shunning was, I think, illustrated quite clearly during the 1960 Presidential campaign. The music editor of the U.S. magazine *Saturday Review* queried both Presidential candidates for their answers to two questions:

1. Are you in favor of establishing a post of Secretary of Culture with Cabinet rank?
2. To what extent do you believe the Federal Government should assist in the support of museums, symphony orchestras, opera companies and so on?

According to published reports, both candidates rejected the idea of creating a Cabinet post for a Secretary of Culture. Neither seemed to think that Federal aid to domestic cultural activities, institutions and projects should